



FREE: WHERE? DOWNLOADING FREE MUSIC

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You don't have to live with the guilt of stolen music anymore. Musicians all over the world are using MP3 as a promotional medium

Listen.com

With over 1,30,000 recording artists under its listings, this is the big momma when it comes to free music. But here's the deal. Listen.com does not host the files; instead it points you to other labels where you can find them. Five major record labels have invested in listen.com, and it's all legitimate.

Epitonic.com

This is a site started by some obscure and independent labels, which is probably why they use the words 'underground' and 'cutting edge' to describe their music. From electronica, to punk, indie and experimental music, you'll find it here. An interesting feature of the site is that it carries in-depth reviews by the editors along with picks of the week and descriptions of songs. The

blackbox feature on the site lets you store an unlimited amount of songs on epitonic.

Technomusic.com

This online record label has a plethora of free techno MP3s broken down into nine different sub genres. You can download or preview all songs on the site or listen to its streaming radio.

MP3.com

While the site is known as a vehicle for unknown artists, quite a few big names too can be found here. Anyone can upload MP3s to MP3.com, so you'll find a wide variety of artists from the also-rans to the famous ones.

Audiogalaxy.com

This site calls itself a 'community of fans and artists'.

After the RIAA intervention, Audiogalaxy has cleaned its act and now hosts only legal music. With a 'sounds like' feature and introduction to various new genres, this site lets you find some real gems.

RollingStone.com

A true 'brand name' in the music business, the site offers free downloads of selected tracks from top artists. Registration is required, but it's free.

Amazon.com Digital Music Downloads

Best known as 'Earth's Biggest Bookstore', Amazon now offers free MP3s from hundreds of well-known artists, including rare and previously unreleased tracks. Independent artists may offer music for download and set up virtual tip jars.



A perfectionist's list of MP3 rules

- Always follow a standard naming convention for your MP3 files and folders; for individual songs use 'Track number_Artist_Songname.mp3' and for albums use 'Artist_Album' as the folder name. Widely used and accepted, this convention makes your collection easier to browse through.
- Put ID3V2 Tags on your newly ripped MP3 files from CDDB entries, or do it manually. This helps automated sorting of music, and is especially helpful when you need to browse loads of MP3s on a portable MP3 player or rename them using a new convention.
- Delete wrong ID3 Tags from files and replace them with the right tag information using a tool. Using a tool such

- as ID3Killer, you can mass-remove incorrect ID3 tags from Internet downloaded music and rename it to proper tags manually, or using tools such as Tag&Rename.
- 192 K or similar bandwidth variable bitrate files have pretty much become a standard for ripping from an audio CD. This bitrate preserves most of the audio, and doesn't hog too much disk space either.
- While archiving MP3s to a CD-R, make sure you keep a database of all the MP3s you archived in a tool such as Broken Cross or MP3 Database. It helps keep duplicate downloads to a minimum, and makes searching for a certain archived song easy, as the tool will tell you which CD you wrote it to.